

ADCLOD Podcast Series with Social Impact Founders

Episode 10: Dr. Urvashi Sahni, SHEF

Neharika Vohra: Welcome to the ADCLOD podcast series with social impact leaders, an initiative by the Ashank Desai Centre for Leadership and Organisational Development at IIM Ahmedabad, where we document and celebrate the leadership journeys of India's homegrown social entrepreneurs and institution builders.

Neharika Vohra: In today's episode, we speak with Dr Urvashi Sahni, founder and president of Study Hall Education Foundation, based in Lucknow. For four decades, Dr Sahni has worked on a question that goes beyond enrolment and literacy: can education transform the conditions of a girl's life — her sense of self, her capacity to resist, her right to choose her own future? Founded in 1986, SHEF is not simply a school network; it is a laboratory for critical feminist pedagogy, a philosophy Dr Sahni developed to help girls from marginalised communities in Uttar Pradesh understand the patriarchal structures that shape their lives and find the agency to resist them. At its heart is Perna Girls School, established in 2003 in Lucknow, which today serves over 1,000 girls from urban slums. Through its Digital Study Hall, SHEF has extended its pedagogical practices to over 100,000 teachers and students across Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan. Across its schools, programmes and government partnerships, SHEF's work has reached an estimated five million children.

Neharika Vohra: Dr Sahni's own journey into this work is inseparable from its content. Married at 17, she found that even her own education — pursued later at the University of California, Berkeley, where she completed a PhD in education — had not given her the tools to resist the forces that constrained her. That personal reckoning became the foundation of her life's work. She founded Suraksha, a women's rights organisation, in 1983, before establishing SHEF in 1986. She has since founded Didi's, a social enterprise for sustainable livelihoods that employs Perna graduates and their mothers, and is a catalyst for 2030, a global network of social entrepreneurs. In 2011, Dr Sahni was awarded the Ashoka Fellowship; in 2017, she was named Social Entrepreneur of the Year India by the Schwab Foundation and Jubilant Bhartia Foundation, and named to the BBC 100 list. In 2024, she was selected as an Advanced Leadership Initiative Fellow at Harvard University. She is a non-resident fellow at the Centre for Universal Education at the Brookings Institution, and her 2017 book, **Reaching for the Sky: Empowering Girls Through Education**, was published by Brookings Institution Press.

Neharika Vohra: We are very delighted to have you, Dr Urvashi, with us today. It's a pleasure to be able to speak with you.

Urvashi Sahni: Thank you very much, Neharika. Thank you for having me on this podcast, and thank you for all your very kind words — you had me blushing there. When people give you words like that, you have to try and live up to them.

Neharika Vohra: It's quite amazing, the work you've been able to accomplish, and we very much look forward to hearing from you. Dr Sahni, let's start with what SHEF looks like today — the schools, the communities it serves, its teacher training programme, and the reach of the Digital Study Hall across Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan.

Urvashi Sahni: Wonderful, let me start with the vision. It's to educate everyone — children, adults, men, women, anybody — for gender justice, gender equality, social justice, personal flourishing, and active democratic citizenship. We do that through the schools we run ourselves: Study Hall, and now Study Hall Two, which is still quite young, along with a Study Hall franchise model that's also just getting started. Together, those three have close to 3,000 children.

We also run a school in a village called Vidyasthali, which serves children from 110 villages nearby — all of our schools go from pre-K to class 12. There's Perna, our school for girls from very poor communities, with 1,200 girls, and a small boys' school of about 200, which we've deliberately kept small by design. Beyond these schools, we realised there were many children who couldn't travel to any school at all — some of them children of sex workers, working children — so we set up community-based learning centres for them, run by the community itself, with teachers drawn from the community, for the community. Those have been very successful — we now have about 100 of them, with more communities asking for them, reaching roughly 4,000 children. We also run a college, again fairly young, with about 350 students coming from 30 surrounding villages.

Beyond the schools, we developed critical feminist pedagogy at Perna, and we've since taken that curriculum to about a thousand schools — 740 of them in UP, including every Kasturba Gandhi Balika Vidyalaya across all 77 districts, and 200 in Rajasthan — and we're hoping to scale it further. We've also developed a critical feminist pedagogy curriculum for boys, which we're still piloting; our own programme just went through a third-party evaluation with strong results, and we've expanded it from 43 middle schools to 100 high schools, because we genuinely believe this work has to include boys too — we're now training teachers in a hundred boys' schools to run the programme there.

And then there's Digital Study Hall, whose goal is to take the best practices from our own schools — which are well-resourced, with highly trained and creative teachers — and film those lessons for wider use. We run a YouTube channel, DSH Online, where the lessons are free of cost, covering kindergarten through class eight, following the UP Board curriculum, though the underlying concepts apply just as well to CBSE. We also have 800 to 900 of those videos on Diksha, the national teacher platform, so they're reaching well beyond our own schools. Alongside all of this, we advocate quite aggressively and enthusiastically for gender equality, against domestic violence, and against child marriage. We run a large campaign called India's Daughters, both digital and in person, where our students, teachers and community members march against child marriage in their own communities, get community members to sign pledges, stage plays, and push back directly when parents argue that seventeen is old enough. That's the sum total, in brief, of what we do.

Neharika Vohra: That's a great deal of work. How many people work at SHEF? I imagine there are teachers, field staff, and more across these different threads — what's the overall size of the organisation?

Urvashi Sahni: We're upwards of 450 people, including several interns — teachers, field workers, and everyone working through Gyan Setu, our community-based learning centre initiative. That's our team.

Neharika Vohra: And is that mostly concentrated in and around Lucknow, or spread across UP?

Urvashi Sahni: The team itself works within about a five-district radius around Lucknow, but our reach extends across all of UP — for example, we train teachers throughout the state. We also worked in Rajasthan a few years ago; I served on the Chief Minister's Advisory Committee there, and we trained master trainers in collaboration with UNICEF across all 200 KGBVs in the state. They're carrying that work forward now, though we're not actively involved there anymore.

Neharika Vohra: What does KGBV stand for?

Urvashi Sahni: Kasturba Gandhi Balika Vidyalaya — residential schools that originally started as middle schools, classes six through eight, and now, thanks to advocacy from many of us, go all the way up to class 12. There are over 4,000 of them across India's most educationally backward blocks. The thinking was that girls become most vulnerable to child marriage and dropping out right around puberty, so in the most backward blocks, they set up residential schools — about a hundred girls each — to at least get them through class eight. Many of us then pushed further, saying the work was only half done, because families would simply marry girls off right after class eight — so the schools were extended to class 12, which has now happened in UP and several other states, following an earlier example in Jharkhand.

Neharika Vohra: When were the KGBVs first set up?

Urvashi Sahni: I honestly don't remember the exact year, and I'd rather not guess.

Neharika Vohra: No problem at all. Are they similar to Navodaya Vidyalayas?

Urvashi Sahni: No, quite different. Navodaya Vidyalayas take the very top academic performers — I believe the cutoff is around 90% — from class six through twelve, and the goal is to give the most talented students every possible opportunity. KGBVs work the opposite way: need, not merit, is the criterion. The goal is to reach the poorest, most disadvantaged and most at-risk girls, and do the best possible with them.

Neharika Vohra: I see — and you've been working with those schools since 2017. On a simpler note: why did you name the organisation Study Hall Education Foundation? It has a slightly unusual ring to it, almost like a hospital.

Urvashi Sahni: Let me tell you — we were founded in 1986, so we're 40 years old now. I started in my own garage; at the time it was a preschool, because you inevitably start small, with just six children. There was a school in Delhi at the time called "Study" that I really liked the name of — elegant, short, and light — though obviously I couldn't just lift it wholesale. There was also a "Tara Hall," where someone I was working with had gone, and "Hall" sounded good too. So we settled on Study Hall. Later, when we became a foundation, it made sense to call it Study Hall Education Foundation — and since that's a mouthful, the acronym SHEF stuck.

Neharika Vohra: It's unusual enough that you never forget it. Over these four decades, starting with just six children, I'm sure there have been stories or incidents involving your students that have really stayed with you — one or two moments of real transformation that filled you with optimism?

Urvashi Sahni: Absolutely — though a small correction first: we started with six boys and girls together, not just girls. Study Hall, our first school, is co-ed; Prerna is our only all-girls school, everything else is mixed, though our core focus remains girls' empowerment, alongside a newer, distinct focus on boys' empowerment, which I can come back to.

On the girls' stories — there are many, but let me tell you about the one that really gave birth to critical feminist pedagogy. I was working with about ten girls in class ten at the time, trying to help them build a sense of self. We used collage-making — I asked them to build a collage around what they feared most in life. They did, and then we talked about it at length, danced a little, did some role play, but mostly just talked, cried, and shared — I shared my own fears too. Then we asked: how do we work through this fear? What would the future look like without it? And they built these extraordinary collages of themselves flying, soaring, becoming pilots and computer professionals. It was a project that ran for about a month. At the end, I asked how they felt, and one girl said something — in Hindi, she said she felt that now she had a self, whereas before she had simply lived. I was overjoyed. As they were physically putting those collages together, they were really constructing a self, and that was the whole point.

Women — and especially girls raised in very patriarchal settings, and I can speak to my own experience here too — are taught to be self-effacing; any assertion of self is treated as selfish or arrogant, something there's simply no space for. There are rules: don't talk too much, don't argue, and above all, don't question. That's no place to build a self. When the girls told me what they feared, it was their families, being raped, being married off, all the constraints closing in on their futures — and I could resonate with much of that myself. That's what struck me, and it's where the idea of critical feminist pedagogy really came from: that when people come together and tell their stories in a safe, respectful environment, and listen to each other's fears and anxieties, that's when a self genuinely begins to emerge.

That's where critical feminist pedagogy was born, out of that project. The theoretical roots trace back to Paulo Freire, the great Brazilian educator and revolutionary, whose critical pedagogy held that you must first name your world in order to transform it — that you have to examine the structures your life is embedded in, and how they shape you. Freire spoke mainly about adult men, though, so I added the feminist layer: that women and girls need to look at their world through that same critical lens, so they can recognise themselves as equal persons with a right to equality, autonomy, and respect. We built that into a full curriculum over time, scaled it, and eventually realised we needed to build a parallel version for boys too, with a somewhat different focus — which is how the boys' curriculum came about.

Neharika Vohra: Very interesting. On Perna Girls School — I understand it started with a fee of ten rupees a month, and 30 girls. Is that right?

Urvashi Sahni: Yes.

Neharika Vohra: And how many girls attend now?

Urvashi Sahni: There are 1,200 girls now, and the fee is well above ten rupees — it averages around 200 to 300, though 30% of families don't pay at all; there are scholarships for those who can't afford it, and a partial discount for families with multiple daughters enrolled, though I'm honestly not fond of thinking of it in those terms. It began in the afternoon, in the same building as Study Hall, running from 2 to 6 p.m., and I'll tell you — if it hadn't run in the afternoon, many of these girls would never have been able to come. Many of them were already working; the fee was affordable, and the timing meant they could keep their jobs and still attend. Many enrolled themselves, having heard from friends who'd dropped out that this school existed and worked around their day.

We use the NIOS curriculum rather than the UP Board or CBSE, for a couple of reasons. Many of these girls arrive at 11, 14, 15, 18 years old with no schooling at all, or having dropped out as early as class three, so there's a lot of catching up to do — we run bridge courses and accelerated learning programmes, and there's real flexibility in the curriculum; you can drop certain subjects if needed, and you don't have to pass every exam in a single attempt, though many do regardless. What started as more of a programme now runs like a full school. And interestingly, as aspirations have grown over the years — where once we struggled just to get parents to send their daughters to school — many parents now push us the other way, insisting their daughter sit the UP Board or CBSE exams instead of NIOS, so they can go on to a mainstream school after class eight. Three cheers to that.

Neharika Vohra: Absolutely. Having done some school-related work myself, I'm curious how you maintain quality in the curriculum — teachers need to be sensitised, they move on, motivation dips. How do you manage all of that?

Urvashi Sahni: From day one, because we weren't following any prescribed pattern, we were constantly learning ourselves, which put a real focus on our teachers' professional development. I'll be honest — I have very little faith in the standard BA degree most teachers arrive with; the curriculum they've studied isn't bad, but somehow it translates into a heavy focus on rote skill-and-drill methods geared toward exams. So from the beginning, we've run regular workshops — on academics, and separately on critical feminist pedagogy, which starts with dedicated training and continues through ongoing sensitisation. Teachers are encouraged to hold critical dialogues with each other regularly, because no matter how evolved we think we are, patriarchy runs so deep in all of us that it resurfaces in small ways constantly, and needs continual, active unlearning. We do this

together — everyone who's been here long enough — and increasingly peers do it for each other, supported now by a dedicated teacher training team, though it started with me and our vice principals doing it directly. Our principals are expected to be academic leaders in their own right.

A lot of it comes down to simply talking with teachers — not framing it as an instruction from above, but asking, doesn't this make sense? The goal is that children learn, and learn authentically; you can't say "I taught it well" if the child didn't actually learn — that just means you need to find another way to teach it.

On critical feminist pedagogy specifically, women teachers tend to take to it very naturally — we spend time helping them reflect on their own gendered lives and experiences, and once that clicks, they immediately see why things need to change, at least for their own students. With teachers who push back and say this isn't our job, it's the parents' job — I remind them that we all went to good schools, with strong academic records, but nobody taught us that we were equal people, deserving of autonomy and respect. A narrow focus on academics alone won't change your students' life outcomes, and isn't that the actual goal? Men tend to take a bit longer and get defensive at first, but they get there too if you stay with it — and it turns out to genuinely benefit boys as well, which I can speak more to later. I wish you could sit in on one of our students' critical dialogues — they're extraordinarily engaged, vibrant, and willing to challenge power structures and ask the unaskable questions. Those really are the transformative moments in their lives.

We started this work in 2009, focused only on girls, and I'll admit — guilty as charged — I initially didn't see the need to work with boys at all. It was actually the girls' own parents who pushed me on it, pointing out that while we were empowering their daughters, their sons were hanging around street corners making life harder for those same girls. So we took a very small, cautious first group — by design we've kept it to about 200, now closer to 250, despite far more demand. Our theory there was that while patriarchy seems to hand boys privilege and power, especially relative to their sisters, it's worth asking what it's actually doing to them — why should you alone bear the burden of providing for your family? Why shouldn't your wife or sister share the care of your elderly parents? Why should you be the one raising a dowry, when the toll of dowry falls hardest on your sister but the stress of raising it falls on you and your father? Why aren't you allowed to cry, or seen as weak if you do? Why are you called a sissy for wanting to be a nurturing father? The goal is twofold: building empathy for girls and the constraints on their lives, and building a different, less domineering and violent conception of masculinity — one grounded in care, sharing, and nurturing, which doesn't make you less of a man, but arguably more of one.

Boys get defensive at first, so the framing matters enormously — you can't tell them this work exists only to make girls' lives better, as though they're the villain being fixed for someone else's benefit. The message has to be that their own lives matter to us too, and that we want them to thrive and flourish as whatever kind of person they can be — and that doing this work is genuinely good for them, lightens their own burden, and is good for the women in their lives too. It's a win-win. A recent third-party evaluation, including a control comparison against boys from a similarly disadvantaged school, showed a striking difference — even parents and sisters noticed the change, because we work with families too. I'm now advocating strongly that gender studies, in this dialogic form, should exist in all schools — given the scale of gender-based violence in this country, four cases reported roughly every hour, and that's before counting the unreported ones, including all the family and incestuous violence nobody even tracks. It's a serious epidemic, and schools are exactly the right place to address it, because that's where equal habits of mind get built.

Neharika Vohra: Absolutely — and that's good for both men and women; it just makes for a better society altogether.

Urvashi Sahni: I came to this understanding quite late myself, and honestly, globally this is still an early-stage conversation. I'm part of the Echidna Global Scholars Program, women working on gender and girls' education worldwide, and I'm often the only voice raising the question of boys. I went to a girls' education conference in Mauritius, led by a foundation, with attendees from all over the world — again, I was one of very few raising it, though there was real interest once it was named. It matters that this message spreads, because if boys are left out of the conversation, the goal simply won't be achieved.

Neharika Vohra: And misogyny isn't only men disliking women — women can hold it against other women too, especially when a woman asserting herself is perceived as a threat, and systems converge to make sure she doesn't rise. We need equal minds — that idea of an equal mindset feels really important.

Urvashi Sahni: We need it in higher education too. I give talks in colleges and universities, and every time, people sit up — many have come to me afterward saying we need more of this. My response is always: then start it yourselves, don't wait for professors to lead it. Start a student group. I'd encourage you to take that up too, Neharika.

Neharika Vohra: One last question on the organisation itself — how do you financially sustain all of this, given how modest the fees are?

Urvashi Sahni: Study Hall, our first school, is a fee-paying school for middle-class children, and everything else really grew out of that. The building Study Hall is housed in was built up bit by bit as money came in, and in the afternoons it sits vacant — real estate is the single biggest cost in education, so Perna runs there instead, using the same classrooms, computer lab, science lab, even the swimming pool. That made it dramatically cheaper to start. We've paid for a great deal of our early work by ploughing Study Hall's profits back in — we did the same for Vidyasthali, which we set up small with our own funds and grew from there, sometimes with support from friends and family, before we ever had outside donors.

Over time we've found donors who believe in the work. For Vidyasthali, I have a long-term donor partner — we charge a modest average fee, around 500 to 600 rupees, that doesn't even cover 40% of the actual cost, and he's covered the rest for over a decade. For Perna, we again rely on donors — two of whom recently pulled back, leaving a deficit that Study Hall's income currently covers. Gyan Setu is funded by Echidna Giving and, earlier, by UNICEF, which funded our first nine districts of training work, since that kind of training is expensive and not something we could otherwise afford. All of our funders have stayed with us for years — and honestly, the good news is that anyone who visits and sees the work firsthand doesn't leave without wanting to support it. We have high-net-worth individuals, alumni groups from IIM Lucknow, and a range of smaller and larger donors, and between all of that, we manage. We always keep looking for more, though, because when funds run low, more is simply needed. And we cross-subsidise wherever we can — charging families who can pay more, and not charging those who can't; Study Hall's fees, our new urban Study Hall campus, and Vidyasthali are all priced differently depending on the community's paying capacity, with scholarships filling the rest.

Neharika Vohra: Very nice. Could you share one or two examples of women who've come through Perna and really shown what they learned — standing up for themselves, or changing the course their life was on?

Urvashi Sahni: My favourite — and this happened right in front of me — is a girl called Khushbu. She's in my book, and she's fine with her name being used; she believes people should know her story and draw strength from it. Her father tried to marry her off at nine, and we intervened and managed to stop it. She went on to top her class ten exams, and then he came back — he'd found a boy willing to pay 50,000 rupees, and he intended to marry her off regardless. She refused. I remember this clearly: she was sitting right in front of me in my office, her father at the table, and she simply dug in and told him, no, she would not marry him, and he couldn't force her. He threatened her — even talked about killing her — and when I said, sir, you're talking about murder, he told me quite plainly that for two or three lakh rupees, that sort of thing could be made to disappear. I was stunned, and genuinely frightened for her.

Sure enough, that evening we got word that he had beaten her with an iron rod for her defiance. Her stepmother, who lived with them, apparently watched and even cheered him on — but her grandmother reported it. We got the police and Childline involved, and she was rescued; she lived with her grandmother from then on. When I later visited the house, the stepmother was furious that word had gotten out, worried about what the neighbours would think. Khushbu went on to finish class 12, earn a bachelor's degree, and then a master's in gender studies. She now works at Didi's as second-in-command, supports her grandmother, is happily married by her own choice, and has a young son.

There's another girl, Meetu, whom we couldn't stop from being married — she wasn't especially young at the time, and she insisted. Five years later, in an unhappy marriage with a two-year-old, she was washing clothes one day when she suddenly thought — is this really what the rest of my life is going to be? She remembered we'd once talked about how you can study at any age, dropped what she was doing, soap still on her hands, and ran straight to the principal's house nearby to say she wanted to come back to school. She now has a master's degree, works with us, has divorced her alcoholic and abusive husband, and her daughter is thriving.

Neharika Vohra: Wonderful. You mentioned Didi's earlier — could you tell us more about it, and the thinking behind starting it?

Urvashi Sahni: There's another girl worth mentioning here too — Deepthi, an orphan being cared for reluctantly by her brother, living in conditions I can barely describe. She applied entirely on her own, sat through the interviews herself, and won a scholarship to the United World College in Singapore — she leaves in August, and I can't tell you how thrilled we are. It seemed almost too good to be true, but it happened. Another of our girls, after a setback with a similar application, wasn't deterred at all — she's determined to become a doctor, a cardiologist. We have girls who've become lawyers. They've flourished.

On Didi's — it grew directly out of Perna. I saw how poverty was such a curse, driving so much of the darkness in our girls' lives, and realised how helpless people remain without any financial control over their own circumstances. At the time we had a canteen at the school, run by an outside contractor. I asked one of our teachers, Veena Anand, if she'd take it over, with me just supervising, and have two of the Perna mothers employed to run it under her guidance. That small canteen has grown into an

organisation employing 65 women — Veena is still there, 23 years on, and it's run entirely by Prerna women, managing everything from accounts to customer relations to the kitchen and stores; Khushbu works there too, on a decent salary. Today it has an annual turnover of around 3.5 crore rupees, with profitability of around 9–10%, and it's grown well beyond the school canteen — they now run catering for corporates, Reliance, Indus Towers, HDFC Bank, and more. It's an organisation run by women, for women, and of women. It's also a place where girls can take part-time jobs while continuing their own education, and many have funded their higher studies that way. It grew out of the school but isn't formally part of SHEF, since our mandate doesn't cover running a food business — it has its own board, and I'm on it, which is my only formal link to it now. Veena and the women there run it entirely on their own.

Neharika Vohra: With dark kitchens and quick-delivery food services becoming so common, has that affected Didi's business?

Urvashi Sahni: Not really — the food genuinely feels like home cooking, and one of its real strengths is that people want to be part of something run by women, for women. That said, I've always told them not to expect that goodwill to carry them forever — they have to run a genuinely viable business with strong quality, and that's what will sustain it in the long run. They did run into real trouble during Covid, nearly shutting down under a debt of 65 lakh rupees, but they've since paid all of that off and are back on solid footing. My role now is mostly oversight — mentoring and motivating them while they handle the operational work — and I couldn't be prouder of them.

Neharika Vohra: Do you see any risk in scaling the feminist pedagogy through government systems — that it ends up implemented in letter rather than in spirit? How do you guard against that?

Urvashi Sahni: It is a genuine worry. The core problem is that governance within government schools leaves a great deal to be desired — heavy teacher shortages, absenteeism, teachers pulled into non-teaching duties, and so on; I could go on for a while. That's a real hurdle. In terms of quality, we support teachers through a telemonitoring centre, where they can reach out with any issue, including personal ones, and Suraksha helps with that too. So yes, I do worry, and I'm not naive enough to think everything we offer transfers cleanly to students — it doesn't. If even 60% of it lands, I'm honestly happy, given the many hurdles teachers themselves face.

That's part of why we started with KGBVs — they're centrally funded and residential, so there's more time available, and the absenteeism problem doesn't apply in the same way, since students have to be there. We're also looking at technology now: one of our research assistants, Samar, built a chatbot that lets any teacher ask, on her phone, how to run a particular part of the curriculum or handle a specific dialogue with students. We're not there yet, but we're experimenting and actively looking for technology partners who can help us scale with quality in mind — which is exactly why we've stayed cautious, rather than expanding state by state chasing large numbers. Gender is genuinely complicated, and education is genuinely complex; it's taken centuries to build these structures, so it's not going to unwind overnight. We stay patient, persistent, cautious, and vigilant, to keep the quality intact.

Neharika Vohra: As an NGO, you also have a distinct research dimension that many Indian NGOs don't — and you yourself hold a PhD, with deep grounding in critical pedagogy, feminist pedagogy, theatre and education. How does that inform your work, and is there something others could learn from how research has shaped what you do?

Urvashi Sahni: My view of theory is that good theory has to emerge from good practice, and then feed back into it. All of our curricula are well-researched, but they emerge from the work itself — we don't write something and then pilot it; we work directly with children, keep reflexively adjusting based on what works and what doesn't, and only write it up afterward, in retrospect. Our students are genuinely co-creators of the curriculum, which is part of why I think our research is robust — it comes straight from the ground, informed by theory, but often building new theoretical perspectives out of what we actually find. Critical feminist pedagogy is a good example — the critical part came from Freire, but nobody had built the feminist layer before; we arrived at it by working directly with girls and seeing what worked.

For a long time, the dominant theory in girls' education was simply about parity — get girls into school, keep them there, get them to finish, and their lives will change. That hasn't really borne out on its own, which is part of why the field has moved toward gender-transformative education — genuinely empowering girls means helping them understand power structures, how their lives are shaped by them, and building a systemic lens: that whatever discrimination you face is wrong, full stop, and that the system producing it — patriarchy — isn't natural or God-given, but human-made, historically, and can therefore be unmade, and you have every right to protest it. That framing matters personally too — for a long time I was angry with my own father for not educating me, for marrying me off so young. I was engaged at 17, and it struck me one day that he, too, was simply doing what he'd been socialised to do — that the system is the real adversary, not the individual. That understanding does two things: it liberates you from hating people you should be able to love, while also revealing just how large and daunting the actual system

is, which is where theory becomes genuinely useful in helping you locate what you're up against.

Our research continues in that spirit — we built a comprehensive Life Plan and sexuality education curriculum over five years, again working directly with children throughout. Our products and curricula are heavily research-driven, and we stay very self-reflexive as a learning organisation, constantly examining what's working, what isn't, and adjusting. We publish because we see ourselves as shapers of the sector, not just practitioners within it — we want to help change how education itself gets defined. For too long, education has been treated in purely technical terms — reading, writing, mathematics, the sciences — without much attention to how to live, or to social and political consciousness; critical thinking has only entered the mainstream conversation in the last decade or so, and the National Education Policy has only just caught up, decades late. We think education needs to be far deeper and broader than that, and publishing is how we push that conversation — first academically, and eventually, though not always, into the popular imagination too, building the evidence base for the changes we believe need to happen. That's why we call ourselves a laboratory of innovation.

Neharika Vohra: That makes sense. Looking back across all of it — Suraksha, SHEF, Digital Study Hall, Didi's, and now Catalyst 2030 — what do you feel you've done really well?

Urvashi Sahni: On Catalyst 2030, just to clarify — I'm a co-founder, initiated by Jeroo Billimoria, a wonderful social entrepreneur I deeply respect; about 70 or 80 of us built it together, and it's become a real movement. Looking back at the whole journey, I feel profoundly grateful to have been part of it. I've learned enormously, and I genuinely enjoy this work — there's real joy in doing something meaningful that visibly changes someone's life in front of you. It's been a stimulating, challenging, and joyous intellectual journey, and a challenging but equally joyous and rewarding personal one — I don't really separate the personal from the professional in my own life. Professionally, I feel I've grown enormously through this work, and I've learned so much from my students, my teachers, and so many people on the ground.

I've also had extraordinary mentors — Vinita Bachchi, who taught me Vedanta; Ahalya Chari from the Krishnamurti Foundation, who was the one who first told me I should start a school, and when I protested that I didn't even have a B.Ed, told me I had all the right questions, and that was enough to build on; Anne Haas Dyson at Berkeley, a wonderful theoretician of early childhood education and my advisor there, who pushed me to pursue a PhD when I'd only gone in for a master's; and Rebecca Winthrop at Brookings. When people ask about the hurdles and roadblocks along the way, honestly, I don't dwell on them much, because I never expected this to be easy — so difficulty was never a surprise. Even when my own team comes to me frustrated that something is too hard, I tell them: that's exactly why we're here. I believe, quite firmly and rather in the Buddhist sense, that wherever there are problems, there are solutions waiting to be found, and I'm a diehard optimist. Plenty is wrong with the world and with the systems we work within — I feel that keenly, every day, which is exactly why I do this work — but what I can do is keep taking the next right step, keep making the change I can see needs making in the area I work in, and trust that it adds up. You need many people doing that alongside you — many sisters — and we're building a cadre of them, young people who go on to stop child marriages in their own families, girls who've fought for their friends, brought others back to school, changed their mothers' minds. You end up changing the world one life, one person, at a time.

I don't set out to change "the world" — that's too large and honestly not something I feel able to hold. But I change what I can, and I keep doing that, and I'll keep resisting where resistance is needed, and lend my voice, and give strength to other voices that need to be raised against the system too — a system that's cruel to women, and honestly cruel to men as well, in its own violent way. There's no reason it has to be that way. Why not teach our children to hope, to aim for something better, rather than only teaching them how the world currently works? Why not build in them some sense of how the world could change, and how their own lives could be better as a result — because your life genuinely is better when the world around you is better. That moves you away from a purely individualistic idea of education — get a better job, more crops, maybe move abroad, and otherwise assume you can't do anything about the world. You can do a great deal about the world, and you can build a career that pays you, that's meaningful and joyful, and that contributes to nation-building — which really is world-building.

Looking back, the journey has genuinely been a joy. It's flown by, and honestly, I never started with any blueprint — I never expected quite this much to happen. I just kept following what the moment seemed to need: this needs doing, let's do it; this is a problem, let's find a solution. People sometimes accuse me of doing too many things at once, and I ask them, what am I supposed to do — there's so much that still needs doing, and so I wish there were even more people ready to take on more of it. My team is genuinely wonderful, and I want to be clear — nobody does this alone. Over the years, more and more people have joined, and everyone here works with such a real sense of ownership, mission, and joy — without that, none of this would be possible. The journey wasn't something I constructed; it unfolded.

Neharika Vohra: Beautifully put. You were married at 18, into a new household — I imagine that family carried its own patriarchal norms, and yet you've achieved far more than most women are given room to. How has that family supported you

through this?

Urvashi Sahni: Let me start with my own family of origin. Both my parents came from Rawalpindi, in what's now Pakistan — refugees from Partition, as children. My father was orphaned, and came across with his two younger brothers and two sisters; my parents were married the very day Mahatma Gandhi was shot, 30 January 1948, in Delhi, and then moved to Pune. I was born in a small two-room house with my four siblings, and my father went on to build a large steel company from very little. He was a genuine entrepreneur, and quite a remarkable man — independent-minded in many ways, though I understand now, looking back at where he came from and how alien Maharashtra must have felt to him, unable to speak the language, unused to the food, that the one thing he really held onto was his culture. Unfortunately for me, the part of that culture he held onto hardest was its gendered dimension — he was very clear about what boys and girls should and shouldn't do, and that education wasn't especially important for girls. That made me very angry.

I was then married into a family that was also quite patriarchal, also originally from Pakistan — Peshawar — and also in business, and business families tend to run more conservative. My father hadn't finished class ten, despite being genuinely brilliant, and my mother was educated only up to class eight; all of us siblings were the first generation in our family to finish high school, and I'm still the only PhD in the family, which is a strange kind of irony given how much they now value that. In my marital family, my very existence initially seemed to depend on pleasing my mother-in-law — my father-in-law had passed away, and she was quite depressed; my husband was seven years older than me and didn't put much stock in education. I wanted to finish my bachelor's, so I studied largely on my own — I went to the registrar in Pune, explained I was getting married but wanted to complete my degree, and asked if my attendance could be waived, promising I'd sit and pass my exams regardless. There was no distance-learning option at the time, but he must have been won over by how earnest I was, because he agreed. I'd wake at six every morning and study until nine, then go into Pune for exams. I graduated with first-class honours in political science, sociology and economics, and nobody in either family had much to say about it — I simply carried on being the dutiful bahu alongside it.

I was quite cowed at the time, and would simply absorb my husband's — my now-ex-husband's — more dominating moments, because that's how I'd been raised to respond: never defy the man, never say no. My own mother once told me that wasn't how you were supposed to deal with men — that you say yes, and then quietly do what you want anyway. I remember thinking, you're teaching me to manipulate your own son, and she said, well, you clearly don't know how to handle men.

When I wanted to pursue my master's, inspired by Vinita Bachchi, who was teaching me Indian philosophy — I wanted to properly study the purpose of life — I was thrilled just to have finished my bachelor's, and she pushed me to go further. No woman in my family had ever done an MA. My mother-in-law was quite annoyed, asking why I'd bothered getting married if this was what I wanted, and my husband at the time actually complained to my own parents, asking them to talk me out of it — he only had a bachelor's degree himself, though I didn't fully register the significance of that at the time. I went ahead anyway, missed the first year, attended the second, and learned an enormous amount.

Going abroad came next — and to his credit, my husband did support that. Ahalya Chari was the one who first told me to apply abroad; I applied to Harvard, Berkeley, Chicago, Urbana-Champaign, and two others, and was admitted to all of them, which I still find a little astonishing — ignorance really can be bliss, because if I'd known better I might never have applied at all. I chose Berkeley over Harvard because I'd heard it was more radical, and it felt more welcoming. My children were eleven and thirteen at the time, and I was deeply anxious about leaving them, but my husband told me it didn't matter, that I should go — it was just a year for the master's, and his mother would help hold things together at home. My own mother wasn't happy about it, nor was my father, but I went. When it came time to pursue my PhD, nobody was happy about that either — Anne Haas Dyson pushed me to apply, I received a full scholarship, and I went regardless.

Things between my husband and I were never especially compatible, even so — he did support me in starting the school out of our home, and when we struggled to get a loan for the building, he mortgaged our own front door to help pay it back, which I remain genuinely grateful for. But eventually the marriage didn't survive — not because he was a bad man, but because we were simply too incompatible. In terms of support, I probably received more from my marital family than from my own parental one, though that support always came with conditions attached — toe a certain line, and something else in return; I suppose it was a trade-off of sorts, and I can't complain too much given everything else.

My father, interestingly, became my biggest supporter and donor in the end — because he changed, largely, I think, because I changed. He eventually told me I'd done everything he could ever have hoped for, and that he was deeply proud of me — that was a genuine revelation, and I hold it very close. He sent me money when I was running short for Purna; I used to joke with him that he was paying for his old sins — he hadn't educated me, so now he was doing it for my students instead. He's passed away since, and I was very grateful for that closeness before he did. My mother was always my supporter, in whatever way she

could manage, though she was often kept in check by my father — until, eventually, he became one of my strongest supporters too, in the end, because I had changed. And I firmly believe that's how it works — it's like a Rubik's Cube: change one thing, and everything else starts to shift. I tell my own students the same thing: when you change, believe it or not, the world shifts a little in response, because you have. So don't spend all your energy worrying about changing the world — worry about changing yourself, and things will follow.

Neharika Vohra: It's been so lovely talking with you, Urvashi. My last question — I'm sure many people listening are hoping to make some kind of change themselves, whether in their careers or in how they live. From your own experience, are there one or two things you'd want to tell them?

Urvashi Sahni: Absolutely — and I'll tell you what I tell my own students. One thing that's helped me, and I think would help anyone, is holding a more expanded sense of self. You can think of yourself as just you, in this body — or as yourself and your family, or yourself, your family and your community, or all the way out to your city, your state, your country, your universe. The larger your conception of yourself, the richer you actually are. I'm a great believer in Vedanta, and the Mahavakya **Aham Brahmasmi** — that I am part of Brahman, and Brahman is part of me; that I am part of everything that exists, and everything that exists is in me. When you think of yourself that expansively, even your self-interest becomes enormous in scope, and it's a far more joyous way of being than a narrower conception of self.

The second thing — and I've found this true in my own life — is that money is something everyone chases and treats as the measure of all value and success, but I really believe it should be a by-product of your work, not the goal itself. Just as happiness has to be forgotten to be found, money has to be set aside as a goal, in a sense, to actually arrive. Chasing it directly is a rather narrow thing to aim your life at. Make the work your goal instead — find something solid and meaningful that genuinely gives you joy and a sense of purpose and time well spent, and the money tends to follow. If you chase it directly, that may be all you end up with, and even that isn't guaranteed — and there'll be little joy in it either way.

Money is only one kind of value; there's a great deal else that gives a life its worth. I'm nowhere near the richest person in the world in that narrow sense, but I feel like the richest person in the world, because of the value I see around me — created together with so many others — and that makes my life immeasurably richer. So whatever career, whatever work you choose — think of it as work, not career — make sure it's meaningful, purposeful, and in service of others. The more expansive your sense of self, the more people your life touches positively, and the richer you become in that sense — Hitler, too, touched many lives, so I don't mean impact in that neutral sense; I mean impact in a genuinely positive way.

And finally — wherever there are problems, there are solutions; don't let yourself get overwhelmed by the scale of them. Be a solution-seeker. Stay with the problem, stay with the questions, and the solutions will come — usually alongside other people, not in isolation. That's such a joyous way to spend a life.

Neharika Vohra: Not individually — together. Urvashi, it's been lovely meeting an activist, a philosopher and a pragmatist all at once — it's rare to find all three in one person. I wish you and everyone working alongside you the very best, and I hope this work keeps growing and changing things as it goes.

Urvashi Sahni: Thank you so much, Neharika — and please, do come and visit us here, you're most welcome anytime. Thank you for the opportunity to talk; I've genuinely enjoyed our conversation.

Neharika Vohra: Absolutely, we'll do that. Thank you.